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Professional legitimacy in flux: academic tutors in a time of uncertainty

Dongdong Pan[a], Yisu Zhou[b] and Seung-Hwan Ham[c]

[a]Shanghai Normal University, Shanghai, China; [b]University of Macau, Taipa, Macau; [c]Hanyang University, Seoul, South Korea

ABSTRACT
Institutional analysis typically assumes professional newcomers use strategic isomorphism to craft a legitimation project. A qualitative study of 31 tutors and their respective clients and managers in Beijing indicates how this project is continually in flux, predicating the life stages of its practitioners. Using the dyad theory of legitimacy, we find that tutors' professional legitimacy is anchored to their ability to meet the immediate expectations of clients when they regard performance boosting as a single-dimensional priority. The tutor–parent relationship is purely market-based and reputation-driven. A tutor's professional knowledge plays a minor role in winning parents' approval as it has been routinized by and embedded in the techno-managerial tutoring agencies. Faced with uncertainty in teaching, tutors are increasingly resorting to ancillary services to retain clients. From this perspective, tutors are being reduced to replaceable service workers. The legitimation project is transient and beyond the grasp of individual tutors.

Introduction

Recent sociological research has increasingly focused on analyzing professional work conditions within contemporary China. Much of this research has provided substantial insights into prestigious professions such as doctors (Yao 2017) and lawyers (Liu and Halliday 2016; Liu 2017). However,

CONTACT Yisu Zhou zhouyisu@um.edu.mo Faculty of Education, University of Macau, Taipa, Macau.
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emerging professions have seen less attention, leading to a gap in our understanding of rapidly evolving professional landscapes.

The teaching profession offers a unique case study here. The growth of this field stems from two sources: state investment in schoolteachers (Liao and Zhou 2020) and rapid expansion of the peripheral practitioners, primarily academic tutors working in the Supplementary Education Industry (SEI), also known as the "shadow education sector" (Lin 2022). According to a report by the Chinese Society of Education (2016), the market size of SEI exceeds RMB 800 billion, with more than 137 million students participating. There were 7–8.5 million tutors nationwide in 2016 compared to 11.87 schoolteachers (Ministry of Education 2017).

These academic tutors represent an emerging profession that allows us to study the dynamism of professional ecology within China. Although tutors may lack formal associations or coherent ethical standards, they are engaged in teaching work and activities within recognizable educational organizations. Rather than strictly adhering to formal definitions, our focus is on "exclusive occupational groups that apply somewhat abstract knowledge to particular cases" (Abbott 1988, 8). It is important to note that tutors and schoolteachers make up the two groups who exclusively deal with teaching work. By examining tutors in relation to established schoolteachers and observing their experiences, we can better understand whether these tutors fail or succeed in establishing their professional legitimacy. This relational approach not only enriches our understanding of legitimacy in under-investigated professions but also broadens our perspective of professional work outside traditional realms of prestige.

Focusing on the K–12 segment within the SEI, typically characterized by public desire, uncertainty, and anxiety (Kipnis 2011; Howlett 2021), offers a noteworthy snapshot of this dynamism. As public schools are tightly regulated by state policies, for-profit Supplementary Education Organizations (SEOs) have grown within the societal niches that schools fail to fill and are now a common sight in shopping malls and neighborhoods. Their classes provide support for overwhelmed parents and generate a growing body of literature primarily focusing on consumer behavior, its effects (e.g., Li 2023; Kuan 2018; Zhang and Xie 2016), motivation (e.g., Yang 2018; Zhang and Bray 2015), and opinions (e.g., Liu, Jiang, and Chen 2020; Lee 2014). However, the experiences of the tutors themselves remain under-researched.

Like all newcomers to a professional field, academic tutors seek legitimacy in their workspace (Aurini 2006). In terms of the sociology of professions, they are attempting to secure a defensible position in an inter-profession turf war.[1] If successful, this will legitimize their claims and grant them exclusive jurisdiction over their tasks.[2] Our main focus is to understand how this legitimization process takes place in the world of

education and to uncover the strategies adopted by tutors in their quest for professional legitimacy.

In this inter-professional competition, tutors, unlike schoolteachers who have established positions within the state apparatus (Pepper 1996), use the market and the ambiguity of state regulation for rapid development (Lin 2022). Their alignment with other service professions comes from the distinct for-profit nature and the corporate structure of SEI.

Our study builds upon Schoon's (2022) relational theory on legitimacy, enabling us to analyze tutors' legitimation project at the micro level. This theory guides us to examine the object of legitimacy, its audience, and their relationship. The co-occurrence of these three elements forms a dyad, which can establish legitimacy. Using this as our stepping stone, we delve into the literature on tutoring and its legitimacy, outline our data collection and research methods, and present our findings. Finally, we provide a comprehensive discussion regarding the tutors' legitimacy project.

Literature review

Observers of Chinese professions have identified a common theme among contemporary professionals: they are entwined within the state apparatus to varying extents. Studies of professions such as doctors and lawyers in China have demonstrated that the state largely delineates their line of professional work (Liu 2017; Yao 2017). Schoolteachers, who work in state schools, adhere to this pattern. Their education, licensing, and career progressions are tightly controlled and meticulously outlined by the state (Pepper 1996). However, as with the fields of medicine and law, the landscape of the teaching profession continues to evolve due to changes in consumer demand. Since the late 1990s, public desire has driven growth within the teaching profession beyond the traditional bounds of schools (Kipnis 2011; Howlett 2021), leading to the development of new professional spaces.

Within the broader educational landscape, SEI and SEOs have emerged as new components to fill such spaces (Bray and Kobakhidze 2015). Compared to public schools, the SEI environment is considerably less regulated (Lin 2022). For practitioners operating in this arena, issues of legitimacy take center stage as they seek to establish a recognized standing within a rapidly evolving system (Pan and Zhou 2023). Consequently, legitimacy becomes a critical field of research.

According to institutional theory, organizations that conform more closely to established models, which provide conventional scripts for operation, have a higher chance of acquiring legitimacy (DiMaggio and Powell 1983). However, SEOs represent an intriguing possible deviation,

as they often secure legitimacy while loosely adhering to these established models. In fact, they abandon some of the most traditional concepts of schooling (Aurini 2006). Such organizations engage in strategic isomorphism, responding to external pressures such as demands for personalized learning, thereby constructing their legitimacy.

In a similar vein, Gupta's (2022) research on the practices adopted by SEOs reveals that they strike a balance between strategic adoption (sticking to formal educational practices) and tactical deviation (diverging from typical school norms). The aim is to render themselves as relevant and appealing educational spaces. Extant research has explored the legitimacy construction of SEOs and the strategies and practices they adopt. International research has found that the strategies they employ have a dual quality (Aurini 2006; Gupta 2022). On the one hand, SEOs emphasize the similarities between tutoring and traditional schooling. Consistent with standard schooling models, SEOs portray themselves as goal-driven, well-organized, and resource-laden (e.g., SEOs and schools both employ a certain number of qualified teaching staff). These similarities are constituents of the typical conception of "good quality education." On the other hand, SEOs differentiate themselves by highlighting distinctions between tutoring and traditional schooling. SEOs often claim that they are more responsive to parent demands, more tailored to individual learners, and more learner-centered (Aurini 2006; Davis 2013). These qualities are what formal schooling often lacks despite their importance. As such, the tutoring industry constructs its own name, distinct from the established state learning institution.

Existing research has several limitations. Firstly, attention to individual tutors in SEOs has often been insufficient. Tutors have been viewed as static tools of SEOs, with little regard given to their emotions, subjectivity, and agency (Gupta 2022). A key area that remains under-explored is how tutors' identities as professional educators are dynamically constructed, contested, and negotiated. Additionally, the congruency of interests between tutors and SEOs is often assumed. However, potential areas of conflict—for instance, clashes between the profit-driven agendas of SEOs and the educational motivations of tutors—need to be carefully considered (Dierkes 2010). Last, the unique Chinese context warrants special scrutiny. The Chinese state system, while clearly defining the space for schoolteachers, leaves the scope and nature of a tutor's role relatively ambiguous. Through careful observation and study, this research aims to fill these gaps.

Navigating these gaps becomes more fascinating when accounting for the resilience and adaptability tutors demonstrate. Despite being perceived as peripheral servicemen and women, tutors demonstrate a level of agency and employ certain tactics to assert legitimacy. Unlike their counterparts

in traditional school settings, tutors often emphasize their unique attributes. For example, where schoolteachers require formal teaching certifications, tutors are expected to hold degrees from esteemed universities and prove themselves as exam experts who can enhance student performance (Gupta 2022; Yung and Yuan 2020).

Working within market-driven organizations, tutors are expected to respond adeptly to students' and parents' needs, feeling the pressure to deliver immediate improvements in student performance (Aurini 2004; Davis 2013). Their personality traits often differ from those of traditional schoolteachers as well. While teachers may be perceived as humdrum or monotonous by students (Aurini 2006), tutors are generally expected to be young, trendy, and even possess a celebrity-like aura (Koh 2014; Yung and Yuan 2020).

Regarding tutor–student relationships, tutors typically foster a closer, more personal bond with their students (Aurini 2006; Gupta 2022). Consequently, their role extends beyond simple education providers, also encompassing roles such as elder sibling figures or instruments for parental control (Hallsén and Karlsson 2019). Therefore, tutors have to fulfill various expectations and roles simultaneously.

In summary, the trait theory approach is often utilized to understand tutors' legitimacy, focusing on certain characteristics, be it qualifications or personality traits. Possessing these specifics enhances tutors' credibility, while the lack thereof undermines it. However, these studies are not entirely consistent. Some suggest that tutors need formal education or teaching experience, much like schoolteachers, to establish their credibility (Davis 2013). Conversely, others insist on distinct elements like educational entrepreneurship (Aurini 2004). These inconsistencies reveal the limitations of the trait theory approach in addressing tutors' legitimacy (for a review, see Gorman and Sandefur 2011). Moreover, the process of establishing tutors' legitimacy is intrinsically tied with their clients—parents and students. The roles of these clients and their interactions with tutors, considerably overlooked in existing studies, should be included in future research to fully understand tutors' professional legitimacy.

This study aims to fill the research gap in understanding tutors' professional legitimacy. The research question we seek to answer is: What is the process through which tutors' legitimacy is established, considering the structural constraints and other influencing factors? Instead of identifying specific attributes that contribute to tutors' legitimacy, as prior studies have done, this study focuses on the dynamic process of legitimacy construction from the tutors' perspective. To frame our investigation, we have adopted Schoon's (2022) relational theory on legitimacy, which synthesizes various approaches to conceptualizing legitimacy. Schoon identifies three integral conditions for establishing legitimacy: expectations,

assent, and conformity. According to Schoon, the state of legitimacy can be deduced by observing the co-existence of clearly defined relational expectations, audience acceptance of the relationship, and the subject's conformity to these mutual expectations (Schoon 2022, 479). Our findings and analysis are presented in line with these three conditions, as illustrated in Figure 1.

Research methods

Our study was conducted in Beijing from October 2019 to January 2020 using an ethnographic approach. We chose Beijing due to its rich and diverse tutoring industry. The focus of the study was on academic tutoring during the primary and secondary education stages across different types of SEOs.

These SEOs were selected based on maximum variation sampling, under categories outlined in the 2016 Chinese Society of Education report: nationwide centers with over 2 billion RMB revenue annually, regional centers earning 100 million to 2 billion RMB annually, and local centers with annual revenue less than 100 million RMB. The tutors included in our study were those who were or are full-time SEO tutors, chosen considering variables such as their gender, education level, subject specialization, grade level, and teaching experience. Our data is confined to tutors specializing in academic subjects. We chose this focus as these are the subjects our target companies majorly invest in. Moreover, the tutor–client relationship becomes particularly evident in academic subjects, where swift performance improvement is a primary motivation for parents seeking out SEOs.

Data was gathered through semi-structured interviews, observations, and document analysis. We interviewed 31 tutors and three managers from 15 different SEOs. The interview guide used complied with Lareau's (2021, 74–82) guidelines. Tutors were also shadowed during their work, and the perspective of the parents was considered by interviewing five

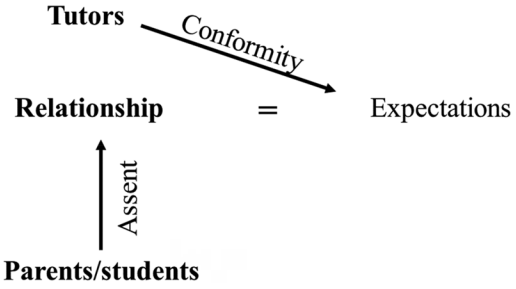

Figure 1. Analytical framework adapted from Schoon (2022).

parents. Additional details about the informants are presented in Table A1 of the Appendix section.

Upon completion of the fieldwork, all interviews, observations, and documents were transcribed and coded. Ensuring the consistency of the data during our analysis phase, we compared and cross-referenced data from different sources, as suggested by Jerolmack and Khan (2014). To maintain the confidentiality of our participants, pseudonyms were used in place of their actual names.

Analysis and findings

In Schoon's (2022) relational theory framework, the presence of legitimacy can be examined according to three elements: *expectation* (from an audience), *assent* (of the audience), and *conformity* (of the object toward the expectation). Legitimacy implies a particular relationship among dyad elements (Schoon 2022). This unit of analysis in the present study is that of individuals. Our research subjects are tutors, and their audience comprises parents and students. Based on observation, it is evident that parents take a more significant role in deciding the tutoring affairs for their children. As such, this study considers parents as the primary audience. Consequently, the parent–tutor relationship becomes our interest of study. The physical interaction between them takes place inside the SEO, while they also have extensive virtual interaction via messaging apps. Both types of interaction occur within the larger corporate environment, constituting a solid yet opportunistic organizational field (Lin 2022). In this section, we analyze the dyad by considering these three conditions.

Expectation

Fierce, high-risk examinations characterize the Chinese education system. Although the state has repeatedly issued mandates to curb school-based test cramming, parental desire remains (Lu, Zhou, and Wei 2022). Parents value their child's school performance. With improved income due to economic development, many Chinese parents also have the resources to spend on educational activities. The government restrictions on public schools and schoolteachers have inadvertently created a space for extracurricular tutoring (Pan and Zhou 2023). SEI has thus quickly filled this new space by attracting parents and students with a specific goal: to boost academic performance.

Purchased educational service

Consistent with our assumption that SEOs are for-profit organizations, their business models typically build on providing a desirable service and

charging a sizable fee. The tuition for a small class with 15 to 30 students can range from 100 to 150 RMB per hour. Parents and students would pay 3200–4800 RMB for a semester-long course, which includes 16 teaching sessions, each lasting 2 to 2.5 hours. Table 1 illustrates the tuition and scheduling of six summer classes from one of our interviewees. Ms. Wu taught six parallel courses in Chinese language arts. Each class hosted 25 students. She was billed for six hours of daily instruction time, a standard teaching load among tutors.

Enrolling with an SEO involves immediate financial expenditure. Consequently, large tuition payments foster high expectations among parents. According to the tutors we interviewed, their relationships with parents and students stray from the traditional "teacher–student" dynamic (*shisheng guanxi*). Often, their role morphs into that of a service provider for parents (the payers) and students (the end users).

Our observations reveal that parents tend not to regard tutors as professional educators wielding authority, but as service providers offering flexible solutions. As a result, the tutors we interviewed reported that their roles and identities blended elements of professional educators, salespeople, and customer service workers:

> The market dictates us, tutors. The market is about buying and selling . . . That is to say, what kind of service someone will have based on what they have purchased. (Ms. Chen, history)

> [We tutors and teachers are] completely different. Parents coming to SEOs have many demands. Since they have paid tuition, they will ask for various things . . . Our company defines [the relationship] in such a way—the

Table 1. Ms. Wu's 2018 summer courses.

Course name	Subject	Starting date	End date	Class size	Total sessions	Duration	Time	Tuition (RMB)
Grade-8 Reading & Writing	Chinese	14-Jul	27-Jul	25	12	2 h	10:20–12:20	3080
Grade-8 Reading & Writing	Chinese	14-Jul	27-Jul	25	12	2 h	15:30–17:30	3080
Grade-8 Reading & Writing	Chinese	14-Jul	27-Jul	25	12	2 h	18:30–20:30	3080
Grade-8 Reading & Writing	Chinese	29-Jul	11-Aug	25	12	2 h	08:00–10:00	3080
Grade-8 Reading & Writing	Chinese	29-Jul	11-Aug	25	12	2 h	10:20–12:20	3080
Grade-8 Reading & Writing	Chinese	29-Jul	11-Aug	25	12	2 h	13:10–15:10	3080

> parents are customers, and the students are consumers. (Mr. Jiang, Chinese language arts)

Among the various expectations of parents, some openly contradicted the professional discretion of tutors. We observed that after class, certain parents would continually approach the tutors to discuss the class that had just concluded. Apart from typical class-related questions, these parents would point to specific classroom procedures and ask the tutor to alter teaching plans according to their preferences. Mr. Jiang, from above, told us that:

> [Parental expectation could be unrealistic] especially in these teaching sites (outside the fifth ring (*Wuhuan*)). Parents here will demand all kinds of things. For example, I assigned students exercises to work on in a fourth-grade classroom for about half an hour. Some parents would argue, "We have paid high fees. We want *laoshi* to teach more, not assign exercises." Even though I have carefully explained to them that students ought to consolidate and practice what they have previously learned, without exercising, students cannot grasp the knowledge well . . . [Pointing to a teaching unit as an example] However, parents want "their money's worth" by letting *laoshi* speak more.

Here, Mr. Jiang's experience is representative of the tutors we interviewed. The parents they encounter increasingly view tutoring as a purchased service. We observed how many parents were eager to have a say in what they viewed as "their service." The SEI's customer-oriented approach also fuels this tendency. By allowing parents inside the classroom and actively demanding the tutors maintain a channel of communication with the parents after classes, the industry is generally pushing tutors toward the role of service workers.

Academic performance comes first

In addition to being viewed as a purchased service, the expectations for tutors also differ in an essential aspect to other teaching professionals, such as schoolteachers. For centuries, the professional roles and tasks of *laoshi* can be summarized as "transmitting wisdom, imparting knowledge, and resolving doubt" (*chuandao shouye jiehuo*) (Lee 2000). This professional ideal established relatively stable expectations in school education. Tutors, on the other hand, have not enjoyed such cultural symbolism. Their professional identity is constantly being negotiated with parents and students.

Existing studies have found that tutors may play a more diverse role than schoolteachers to continue to attract new clients. For instance, they can be considered an elder sibling or an instrument of parental control (Hallsén and Karlsson 2019). However, despite the greater role varieties,

tutors' tasks are more narrowly defined than schoolteachers' tasks. This narrow expectation is centered on improving students' academic scores rather than the overall development of students.

For example, Mr. Shui, a parent, told us that performance improvement is why he signed his child up with the current SEO. He defined tutoring as purely reactionary, "coping for the sake of coping" (*wei le yingfu, er yingfu*), involving no other goals. Ms. Yu, another parent, suggested that it is not the task of tutors to imitate schoolteachers by transmitting wisdom or cultivating the moral values of students. She told us, "If the *laoshi* and SEOs can do these things, it only means that they can forge my child's character" (*renge shangde jiaoyu*). However, character education seems to represent the icing on the cake, not the main dish of why she chose a particular tutor or SEO. For Ms. Yu, boosting performance is the priority.

Making progress not only requires the tutors to be able to deliver classes, but it also requires tutors to actively care for and pay attention to clients who lag behind. This consideration serves as an essential impetus for some parents. In the public school system, limited educational resources and a low teacher–student ratio make it difficult for teachers to attend to every student. The structural restrictions are also mixed with cultural symbolism where the teacher–student relationship emphasizes the dignified authority of the teacher (*shidao zunyan*). Therefore, the typical teacher–student relationship is hierarchical and unequal. Students' affective and emotional needs can rarely be fully met inside schools. SEI, on the other hand, enables such a scenario. Students typically receive a greater degree of care and attention from the tutor. One parent told us:

> The class size in the public school is so large. Sometimes I asked my child, "Why didn't you actively speak up [in class]? Didn't the *laoshi* [schoolteacher] respond?" He said he had raised his hand before, but the *laoshi* [schoolteacher] did not call him. SEOs are very different . . . As soon as one raises a hand, the *laoshi* [tutor] will come over and look at one's work to see whether the student got it right or wrong. As a result, my son likes tutoring. He enjoyed being the first to finish all the assignments . . . Obviously, I feel that he wasn't particularly engaged in school, but he is very willing to take tutorial classes. (Ms. Zou, mother)

The industry predicates fulfilling these expectations to a large extent. Both SEOs and their tutors are keenly aware of such expectations and their value of it:

> Many parents who approached our company are old customers. I think they crave this kind of care. Our service is really good. (Ms. Yang, SEO manager, and senior English tutor)

> Truth be told, parents are very sensitive about whether tutors pay attention to their children. They are sensitive to whether the *laoshi* will initiate contact with them and inform them about their children's situation. (Mr. You, physics)

The above data illustrates that the expectations can be identified as performance-boosting anchored by ancillary services. With the massification of tutoring, it has become a household "product." Consequently, competition among SEOs intensifies. Our interviewees associated SEO brand recognition with the ability to boost performance as a priority end goal. Parents also value the process toward this goal. During this time, they gauge ancillary services, such as attention to their child or timely feedback on assignments, as an indicator of good tutoring. Therefore, the service component created a second layer of expectation. Tutors are expected to display effort and emotion during the learning process and to offer timely diagnoses of the student's learning situation.

Assent

The second element in our empirical assessment is the assent of the audience, that is, their positive evaluation of the relationship. Gaining approval from the client takes work, as several participants in this study have told us. Usually, the students will not openly express their (dis)satisfaction. It is the paying parents who make the most decisions. Therefore, examining how parents evaluate their relationship with tutors is essential to this topic.

Skepticism and recognition

Following their expectation that tutoring is a purchased service, most parents are instrumental in tutors' performance. One can easily mix up tutors and schoolteachers. After all, they are all addressed as *laoshi* or *jiaoshi* (teacher) in Chinese.[3] However, closely examining these two sets of relationships reveals vital differences. The student/parent–teacher relationship is an established one. The connection is embedded in the institutional authority of schoolteachers (Gee 2000). Typically, a student is assigned to a specific school based on place of residence under the principle of proximity. Once enrolled, the student is assigned to particular teachers and, in turn, with a specific group of students. Thus, neither the student nor the teacher has much say regarding their binding relationship. Each party is forced to succumb to externally imposed demands for cooperation (Lortie 2002).

This administrative binding is further reinforced by traditional Chinese culture. Folk traditions such as respecting teachers and valuing education

(*zunshi zhongjiao*) permeate Chinese society. Thus, this student-schoolteacher relationship is characterized by both institutional and cultural legitimacy. The performance aspect is one component. The more prominent cultural role of schoolteachers has already found a secure place in Chinese society (Lee 2000).

On the other hand, while schoolteachers can cling to the symbolic power of the institution or traditional values, a tutor's work is almost solely based upon the approval of the paying parents. Parental attitude is not fixed but is subject to change. This process includes two stages: initial doubt and skepticism, then slow recognition and a positive evaluation if successful.

SEOs themselves are not widely recognized as educational institutions. Although some well-known and large-scale SEOs may have more recognizable brands than others, they are identified as fundamentally different from public schools. Taken together, tutors in SEOs almost always face initial doubt and scrutiny from clients. One tutor told us:

> You see, when parents come to the trial class for the first time, they come with a sense of scrutiny. Will they respect you in the first class? No. They would belittle you as just a *laoshi* from a small organization. Especially in cities like Beijing, parents can even be professors from elite universities such as Tsinghua or Peking University. When they sit at the back, I become very stressed, right? . . . So, at the beginning, why should they respect you? (Mr. Kong, mathematics)

After the initial stage, especially after the trial period,[4] parents who stayed on will gradually approve of the authority of tutors as a professional. This process is characterized both by self-selection and a positive feedback loop. If several sessions have elapsed and the parents sense no noticeable improvement, they will demand a switch of tutors or leave the company altogether. Then, they will start a new round of assessment at the next SEO. Alternatively, among those who stayed, the approval of the tutors is typically punctuated by performance milestones (e.g., several good results in the school assessments) or satisfactory customer experiences (e.g., receiving instructive information via messaging apps, also known as "the good service"). There is no uniform pattern in this iterative process. During our interviews, many tutors concurred that parents' assumptions remain the same; their perceptions could change over time.

During our fieldwork and literature review, we observed that a change in attitude did not come easily. Students' and parents' respect for schoolteachers is enmeshed with institutional and cultural legitimacy (i.e., Gee 2000). Such respect does not necessarily correlate with teachers' performance because education entails a process "of polishing, carving, refining, waxing, and glazing of self," which implies a state of refinement and

gentility (Yen 2005, 46). Regarding tutors, however, parents are not swayed by long-term promises. They expect some quick fixes and nontime-consuming refinement. Many parents who come to an SEO believe that their relationship with the tutor is transactional (*maimai guanxi*) and that tutors are a performance-boosting instrument (*tifen gongju*) (Yang 2017). Therefore, audience approval is not given, but something tutors must work for. Eventual approval hinges on the tutors' ability to provide what their audience needs. Ms. Yang, an SEO manager, told us, "There may be times when you feel that parents are afraid to refute a word from the schoolteachers. That is probably not the case here. Once the scores don't improve, or students' problems are unsolved, parents may express their dissatisfaction directly to my face."

Recognition and action

Within SEOs, parents and students have greater autonomy in choosing a particular tutor (Bray and Kwo 2014). Our interviews confirmed that parents are proactive and actively evaluate the situation on behalf of their children. SEI does not have the kind of binding force that public schools have on attendees. Thus, there is mobility between tutors within and between SEOs.[5]

For tutors who are successful at establishing confidence in their clients, they receive approval in two forms. First, many parents will spread the good word about a particular tutor. Such action serves as a reputation mechanism since there are no established performance indicators for parents. Word-of-mouth type of referrals are the de facto advertisement. All five parents we interviewed discussed the role that referrals from friends and co-workers played in their choices for a specific SEO and tutor.

For instance, Ms. Yu reasoned that some of her friends had spent a lot of time and effort choosing the most suitable SEO for their children. As such, they are familiar with the strengths of each SEO and their effective tutors.[6] Therefore, she adopted these recommendations. The advertisement from parents is also one thing that gives tutors a positive feeling.

The second form of recognition is when clients choose to stay with one particular tutor or, to use the industry jargon, they "renew their subscription" (*xubao*). Most SEOs operate on the logic of performance rather than the type of value-add typically seen in the academic literature (i.e., Guarino, Reckase, and Wooldridge 2015). For SEOs, performance metrics mean the rate toward which they could convert student enrollment into cash flow. Thus, students' renewal rate (*xubao lyu*), full-class rate (*manban lyu*), and refund rate (*tuifei lyu*)[7] are the most talked-about metrics among SEOs. Among the three, the renewal rate is the most prized. SEOs rely on tuition first and foremost and, by extension,

the willingness of clients to stay with them. Unlike public schools, which receive students on a mandatory basis, SEOs must find every willing customer themselves.

Faced with the pressure of turning a profit, SEOs face two choices regarding their clients: (1) recruiting as many students as possible; and (2) stabilizing existing students. To boost new subscriptions is known as customer acquisition (*huoke*) in the industry. Retaining existing subscriptions means ensuring the current customers will renew on time. Between these two choices, the cost of acquiring a new student is believed to be much higher than that of retaining an existing one. Due to this differential, keeping existing students becomes a vital aspect of tutors' work. Being able to receive renewal is an indicator of assent. Conversely, if they are unsatisfied with specific SEOs and tutors, parents and students will most likely vote with their feet. Hence, we see the high mobility discussed at the beginning of this section.

The assenting process is also fluid. Mr. Tao, a senior English tutor and a manager informed us that if an SEO cannot improve a student's score quickly, the parent can easily find another SEO. Evidently, the same parent could not switch to another school at will, even when unhappy.[8] SEOs lack the compulsoriness that schools have, making them more customer-reliant and people-pleasing. SEOs occupy a unique position in the education ecology. Such a position brings new constraints regarding the interactions between practitioners and clients. The tutor is the weaker node than the parent because their work relies on the latter. They are also vulnerable in the broader context of SEI (Pan and Zhou 2023). Tutors are employed by SEOs, who then seek client subscriptions as their source of revenue. Therefore, SEOs are pushing tutors to conform to the client's narrow expectations while, at the same time, seeking other means to increase their stickiness (*nianxing*) toward clients.

Conformity

An instrument for school performance

Do tutors conform to the ascribed expectations? This study's interviews and observations indicate that they do. Some tutors conformed out of professionalism, while others were due to collective norms. When clients put their entire expectation on performance boosting, they narrow the legitimation process to a wire. The parent–tutor relationship resembles typical instrumental rationality, devoid of emotional attachment or value system, while tinted by the individual's purely pragmatic and egoistic interests (Zhao 2015).

Tutors inevitably internalize the audience's expectations. Ms. Wang, who used to work in a public school and is now a tutor, believes that

these two institutions have diverse teaching goals. Parents who come to SEOs have a single-minded target. Thus, the tutors' job is to meet such expectations actively. Mr. Tao, the manager, reasoned that the role and task of tutors are clearly defined as an instrument for performance boosting. The SEI and its practitioners risk losing their legitimacy if they cannot achieve such a goal.

> When you are a *laoshi* in this industry, your existence hinges on being an instrument. When the child cannot keep up with his or her schoolwork, we are the so-called "performance-boosting instrument" . . . Once you lose this value, then your existence is devoid of its meaning . . . It all depends on whether you can raise the child's score. As simple as that . . . If you can do that, [the parent] will continue to follow you. Otherwise, bye-bye. Such a simple truth. (Mr. Tao, English)

Our findings give rise to another inquiry. Pan and Zhou (2023) highlight that the SEI has low entry barriers, insinuating that tutors may not necessarily be exceptional test takers. If that's the case, employing compliance to achieve results may be merely a public relations tactic. Can SEI deliver on its promises?

Beyond using catchy advertisement scripts, parents disclosed that SEOs did help improve their children's academic performance. Adopting a systems-based approach, SEOs distilled their knowledge base and developed comprehensive systems, reducing their dependence on individual tutors' abilities. These national franchise SEOs boast intricate systems that analyze the official school curriculum in detail. These systems extract what SEOs perceive as crucial points to enhance performance. So, while there might be uncertainties, SEOs do seem to make a tangible impact.[9]

In our interviews, all tutors identified an extensive "curriculum development team" within their companies. This group's role is to provide tutors with simple, effective lesson plans and solutions for parent concerns. These preset materials facilitate the mechanical mirroring of parental expectations.

Table 2 demonstrates an elementary English unit lesson plan from a large SEO franchise, the Venus company. The class is divided into 5–15 minute segments for easy interchangeability and simplicity for new tutors. This plan isn't groundbreaking; many beginner schoolteachers create comparable ones. However, the notable point here is the strict adherence tutors must maintain to the plan.

The company chiefly imposes compliance pressure. Table 3 outlines Venus company's performance evaluation metrics. Tutor interviewees mentioned that they need to memorize teaching routines rigorously during initial training, a process they term "grinding the class" (*moke*). Otherwise, they won't clear the assessment. The pivotal moment for this

Table 2. Lesson plan for a 50-minute elementary English class.

Stage & Aims	Procedure	Interaction & Time
Routine & Rules	Attendance call; emphasize the classroom rules; call group number, leading to the bonus system. a) Call attendance by saying each student's name "Hello, Abby!" b) Rules: listen attentively/ raise your hand/ sit well. c) Divide the class into 1, 2, and 3 groups.	5 mins Whole Class
Introduce the topic	Play and let the students sing along with "Baby Shark." Include the parents. Show active body gestures to help the students warm up to the activity. Use hand gestures to differentiate the members across groups.	5 mins Whole class
Present	Using hand gestures to let the student introduce/recall their family members.	15 mins
– Meaning/pronunciation/spelling	Ask students to match a picture with a word card. Show students different syllables; ask the students to read and follow. After students are comfortable with the word, lead them with the sentence: "This is …"	Whole class Invite students to the stage to match syllables or to highlight important syllables.
Practice		
– Test each student's understanding of the words. Practice pronunciation with correction	Exercise 1: "I say, you do! & I do, you say!" The tutor says a word, followed by the student using hand gestures to express the word. The student and tutor switch roles. The tutor uses hand gestures first. Exercise 2: Touch Game The tutor says a word, which is followed by the students coming up to the stage and touching the correct graphic card The tutor and student switch roles. The tutor uses hand gestures first. Pick one from the two exercises above.	10 mins Whole class Invite students to the stage or to work in pairs (modify the touch game)
Practice		
– Improve student's pronunciation and spelling	Exercise 3: Bomb Game The tutor selects a card and utters its corresponding sound. If the word on the card matches the sound, then the student repeats the sound. If it is different, i.e., the word is 'father' and the tutor reads 'mother,' the students say "Bomb!"	10 mins Whole class Invite students to be "little teachers."
– Improve spelling	Complete the reading and writing exercise (student workbook 1 ex. 2). The student should start by writing down words. Use stickers.	5 mins Individual work
Break		

company is an examination 6–12 months post-hire. By then, tutors should have completed mentorship training and are tested on their adherence to prescribed curricula, pedagogy, and protocols. Noncompliance can lead to immediate contract termination.

Table 3. Graduation criteria from mentorship (6–12 months after officially being employed).

Assessment domain	Item
Teaching capability	1. Observe a minimum of 20 teaching sessions of the mentor. Finish developing a minimum of 10 qualified lesson plans. 2. Pass the teaching supervision assessment in the current quarter (reaching the Quality Assurance Department standard).* 3. Pass the random teaching assignment with high quality.**
"Renewal" capability	1. Participate and pass renewal training and assessment (such as a renewal simulation). 2. Submit the tutor–parent communication form on time (missing or late no more than three times). 3. Renewal rate is within the 10% differentials from the department average in the last two quarters.

Notes: *Standard may vary depending on the branches. Standards may include (1) the percentage of English used in class, (2) classroom management skills, (3) student discipline, (4) the number of unfinished sessions, and (5) the degree to which lesson plans are followed. Supervision can be conducted in person or via surveillance cameras.

**A random assignment is where a tutor must teach a random-selected session from the lesson plan they have developed.

Even as SEO bridges the challenges for tutors, unpredictability concerning student performance remains. Factors influencing test scores are extensive and variations are customary (Howlett 2021). Tutors in our study have also reported immediate, drastic reactions from parents following signs of stagnant or decreasing performance. Often, parents become assertive, demanding detailed explanations, or even threatening to cancel subscriptions. Tutors face little scope for error or experimental teaching, which eventually makes their teaching conservative and their emotional state acutely strained due to constant uncertainty. Their credibility and authority are routinely doubted, even after complying with the "performance-boosting" norm, therefore, establishing long-term or stable relationships with their clients can be a struggle.

> Our authority is shaky. Once you cannot meet parents' needs, that is to say, in the most intuitive way, when the child's scores drop, and [when they thought] tutoring brings no effect, the authority will no longer exist. And [our job] stops working. (Ms. Han, founder of a small SEO and former English teacher)

The stress arises from uncertain client performance and the brutal self-realization that tutors are merely working toward being an instrument. Some tutors believe that by conforming to parental expectations, they have become pragmatic, short-sighted educators, not true educators in the traditional sense. The sign of disengagement from work was prevalent among the veteran tutors of this study.

> When the parents treat *laoshi* as an instrument, I will feel my social status belittled … I intermittently have this sense of frustration . . . When my

> mood swings badly . . . I wonder if I should switch to another job. (Ms. Chen, history)

Another corollary is that tutors view their relationship with the clientele as reduced to transactions. Parental respect is believed to be superficial. In the words of Mr. Wei, a Chinese language arts tutor, such a relationship is as simple as "You spend money, I bring you benefits. This thing is fair. You are happy, and I am also happy." Many tutors believe parents will never treat or respect them the same way as schoolteachers. Parents also confirmed such a view. Ms. Zou, a mother with a PhD degree in education, admitted that her attitudes regarding schoolteachers and tutors were quite different.

The increasing importance of service

As described in the previous section, the work of tutors in SEOs is composed of two parts: one part is teaching work, and the other is service work. All the SEO managers we interviewed acknowledged the importance of service. One interviewee showed us her company formula, illustrated in Figure 2. Since offering parents more service is key to retaining customers, SEOs openly ask tutors to conform to such an identity.

According to Ms. Feng, who switched jobs from a public school to an SEO, "feels like giving up all the dignity as a *laoshi*. You are now a servicewoman. … Now you are a servicewoman in the guise of a *laoshi*." Mr. Xie, the founder of an SEO franchise, informed us that the tutoring industry is just "a service industry featuring teaching as a product." He believes that SEI is essentially part of the service industry. Therefore, "[Tutors] should not hold themselves too sacred."

Increasing demand for service thus comprises most of a tutor's working day. Service even squeezes out the time for teaching-related work, such as lesson preparation. At the same time, service work has also evolved from spontaneous initiation to standard operating procedures. Much of this extra service occurs in the virtual world (Pan and Zhou

Figure 2. An excerpt from the Venus company's training manual translated by the authors.

2023). They are invisible on the workload sheet. Table 4 demonstrates how service tasks are also rationalized and pre-programmed. The data was derived from two of the largest SEOs: the Mercury and Venus companies. Due to their similarity, we present them in aggregate form.

Each task a tutor conducts takes a relatively small amount of time. The tasks are performative in nature, as are many other teacher practices (e.g., Ball 2003). Once tutors are engaged in one-on-one situations with parents, preprogrammed messages alone are not sufficient. Conforming to their expectations requires the tutor's affective and emotional labor (Hochschild 1983). Most tutors have learned artificially sincere communication scripts (*huashu*) while on the job.

Among the tutors we interviewed in this study, there was an implicit consensus that "if you cannot teach well, service can compensate" (*jiaoxue bu zu, fuwu lai cou*). This refers to the belief that more service work will lead to a boost in performance metrics. Comments such as the one below were common in the data:

> For parents, test scores are the key. If students can improve their scores, parents will trust the *laoshi*. But for *laoshi,* without enough [performance boosting] experience, service becomes more important. That is to say; one can compensate for bad teaching with good service. Parents have two reasons for renewal: if the *laoshi* here can raise the children's scores; or because the *laoshi* . . . are very responsible for reporting every behavior [and related problems] of their children in the class, and even suggesting related solutions. It doesn't matter if the solutions are workable as long as they are proposed. This is the service side. (Ms. Qian, politics)

For SEOs and tutors, providing ancillary services to parents and students increases the stickiness between clients and the company, a point repeatedly emphasized in situations such as that displayed in Figure 2. We were told:

> In corporate meetings, they will repeatedly emphasize service. Service needs to be good. Where do you get your renewal number from? From the service. Even if you cannot teach well, as long as you serve [the clients] well, you will get rewarded. (Ms. Feng, Chinese language arts)

Taken together, tutors' conformity should be viewed within the broader context of SEOs. In a highly competitive market, SEOs fight among themselves for more customers. Therefore, they rationalize the teaching process by leaving no room for spontaneity. Instead, SEOs embed the knowledge and skills of the organization: prescribed and detailed curricula for teaching and customer-oriented service items. The conformity binds tutors with the SEOs but also corners tutors into a weak position because they

Table 4. General service template for elementary and lower secondary classes.

Period	Item	Service Action
Before any session starts	Setup WeChat group	Send group messages and/or call each parent before the first session.
	Survey students	Use the survey to determine new and returning students.
	Download company app	Guide the parents to use our app.
	Warm up (clock in the app)	One week before the class, introduce parents to the importance of clocking in. Ensure they use clocking-in as a habitual mechanism. Remind students to preview lessons before classes start.
	Teaching aide	Closely monitor group interactions before the first session. Answer parents' questions.
	Meet the parents	1. Send the meeting content as screenshots + voice/text messages to the class WeChat group. 2. Broadcast the meeting in the WeChat group.
	Reminders	1. Pin group announcements three days before the first session. 2. Topics should include: date, time, location, textbooks, installing the app, and class items (stationery, notebooks, water bottle, and bus card). Remind them of class requirements, disciplines, etc. 3. Use personalized phrases to address parents. 4. Follow up one-on-one with parents who did not respond to group messages.
During sessions	Send a reminder before each session	If any physical items are needed in class, ask the parents to prepare them.
	Attendance calls	Call each student's name.
	Clock-in WeChat groups	Assign course-related items for clock-in activity.
	Writing assignments	Assign homework.
	Exams	Walk through difficult questions using PPT. Allow students to finish easy questions themselves.
	Class performance	Raise frequent questions; interact with the students.
	Summarize key items	1. Key time period: class, unit, quarter. 2. Write a personalized summary.
After all sessions conclude	Discuss difficulty level	Are students able to follow instructions?
	Preview before next session	For returning students. For new students.
	Exams	Use different scripts for full-mark and non-full-mark students.
	Develop learning habits	Inform parents about their child's learning habits. Dimensions include preview, review, habit development, etc.).
	Personalized communication (2–7 times)	Class anecdotes, excellent assignments, and clock-in routines.
	Display before first session	New prop, student's own device, highlights from previous online sessions, photos.
	Display after the first session	Photos or screenshots taken by the teacher's aide.
	Display after personalized communication	Positive feedback from parents, excellent assignments, and/or clock-in behaviors.
	Display after all sessions conclude	Self-made certificates (in PPT); attach student's photo; generate personalized congratulatory messages.

exclusively answer to external demands. Tutors' knowledge becomes corporate knowledge in the real sense. SEOs push the rhythms of the "acquisition-teaching/service-retention/attrition" cycle because clients are highly mobile. Thus, the organization wins the jurisdictional claims while its practitioners are constantly on the run.

Conclusion and discussion

Teaching is a multifaceted profession that revolves around managing emotions, boosting motivation, and aiding students through learning challenges (Cohen 2011). This study examines the professional legitimacy of tutors, whose role is shaped by parents' performance-based expectations. We conclude with several implications.

First, cases in our study suggest that tutors, like many modern professions, started with a specialized focus, trying to gain legitimacy over time. However, tutors' professional challenges rise in organizational structures (Abbott 1991). Unlike small-scale independent legal firms (Liu 2017, 75ff), large SEOs hire many tutors who lack collective bargaining and professional protection rights. Drawing on Pan and Zhou (2023), tutors often more resemble laborers vulnerable to industry-wide exploitation than fully autonomous professionals.

Second, the organization obscures tutors' legitimation by denying them professional knowledge development. Abbott's "institutionalization of expertise," includes the delivery of expert service by organizations, expertise hierarchies, and expertise reproduction routines (Abbott 1991, 19–20). Convention conceptualization of a profession would picture this expertise would reside within practitioners. However, our study found tutors lack a personal knowledge system as Abbott (1988, 52ff) deemed crucial for legitimization. Instead, they relied on SEOs for the instruction on teaching, client management, and customer retention. Tutors' abilities to diagnose, treat, and infer audience issues are subsumed within the SEO's scope, leaving them struggling to meet fluid parental demands.

Time introduces a third aspect to our discussion. Tutors and SEOs operate on distinct timelines. Most teaching professions need considerable time for accurate outcome measurements. Immediate learning detection within weeks or a month is challenging, creating what Cohen termed a "unique problem of human improvement" in education (Cohen 2011, 4ff). SEOs, however, driven by competition and profits, focus on short-term customer acquisition and retention. Concurrently, time pressure leads to operational rationalization for maximum subscriptions and prompts tutors to target tangible short-term goals. Notably, while tutors becoming experts in specific curriculum segments align with client expectations, it paradoxically also makes them replaceable in the process.

Our study reveals that tutor knowledge organization involves rationalization and standardization. Unlike many service professions, tutors' time isn't commodified (Sherman 2010), but constricted and steered toward specific knowledge-production modes. The tutors we interviewed felt powerless against the organization, reflecting changes in the tutoring landscape post-2010. Unlike the previous three decades when star tutors attracted clients (Pan 2020; Lin 2022), superior SEO platforms now determine student performance. Furthermore, this rationalization strategy decreases the SEOs' reliance on star tutors. The importance of these tutors gradually diminishes as a systematic approach to teaching and learning takes center stage. As this approach delivers better diagnoses and more impactful results, tutors have become mere replaceable conduits of this knowledge.

Tutors bear the brunt of the rationalization process, typically having short professional lifespans (Pan and Zhou 2023). Amidst uncertainty, they resort to ancillary services for audience approval. In revisiting Schoon's framework, we note that tutors meet the prerequisites for professional legitimacy. However, their roles lack stability and prestige. We suggest that analysts broaden the definition of a singular social object (Schoon 2022, 483) considering the nonvacuum interaction of professionals like tutors. SEOs play a substantial role—beyond teaching (Ball and Forzani 2009)—mediating the relationship between tutors and clients, and housing much of the required professional knowledge. Thus, a tutor's role is inseparable from the organization (Leicht and Fennell 1997).

This study sheds light on China's tutoring industry, tracing its uneasy transition toward organizational rationality where tutors act as supplementary workers. Beyond just observation, our analysis critically evaluates the tutoring profession, underscoring the emergence of new professions in China's rapidly changing social landscape. This paper presents an original perspective on tutors' professional legitimacy, centered within the context of Chinese professional ecology, emphasizing the fleeting nature of legitimacy in a time of uncertainties. It is also worth considering the future of tutors since our last data collection occurred just before the enactment of the Double Reduction policy in July 2021 ("The Guidelines on Further Reducing the Burden of Homework and Off-campus Tutoring for Students Undergoing Compulsory Education"). This policy significantly impacted the SEI and its tutors. Yet, despite the prohibition of SEOs from offering services, the demand for tutoring has not been eradicated. If we can learn anything from history, it is that the desire for tutoring is notoriously difficult to suppress. Although we acknowledge that the entire tutoring ecosystem has been thoroughly revamped, it remains uncertain if the

mediating role of SEOs will continue to influence the process of tutor legitimization.

Notes

1. The general theory is in Abbott (1988). The term "defensible position" is from Abbott (1995, 860).
2. There are many examples in the professional world. Successful projects include medicine (Freidson 1986), law (Liu 2017), and business education (Khurana 2007); unsuccessful attempts are numerous. Abbott (1988) documented several extinct types.
3. We did not replace *laoshi* with either "tutor" or "schoolteacher" in this paper because the difference between the two labels vanishes in oral, daily usage. As discussed throughout this paper, while the names might be the same, tutors' tasks are narrower and distinctive. It should be noted that SEOs never corrected parents for calling tutors *laoshi*, a clear tactic to elicit the cultural symbolism behind schoolteachers.
4. As a promotional strategy, most SEOs would offer free trial classes to parents, either online or in person. Trial class is mostly due to competition among SEOs. With many choices at hand, parents can easily "shop around" for the preferred one.
5. According to our knowledge, there are no statistics on these issues. Our impression is developed based on interaction with interviewees over the years. They switched from one SEO to another frequently.
6. The link between motherhood and education is attracting many researchers. See Goel (2021) for an overview and Yang (2018) for a case in China.
7. The terms vary depending on the SEOs. Common references include "*xubao lyu*," "*xuban lyu*" or "*shengban lyu*."
8. Another parent, Ms. Dou, corroborated Mr. Tao's comment, "There are too many SEOs. … They have to coax me, to make me happy. I cannot do the same in public schools. I coax the schoolteacher."
9. It is worth noting that after our examination of the lesson plans and curricula system of one major SEO, we could not find the term "*tifen*" (performance-boosting). The tutors told us this is because China's Advertising Law prohibits the display of such terms in any published materials. Thus, frontline practitioners will use other ubiquitous phrases, such as "precision analysis" (*jingzhun fenxi*), to appeal to parents.

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ORCID

Dongdong Pan http://orcid.org/0000-0002-8414-8904

Yisu Zhou http://orcid.org/0000-0001-9246-9700
Seung-Hwan Ham http://orcid.org/0000-0001-9965-3113

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About the authors

Dongdong Pan is an assistant professor at the School of Education, Shanghai Normal University. His research focuses on the identity and labor process of academic tutors in China.

Yisu Zhou is an associate professor at the University of Macau's Faculty of Education. Zhou is also a sociologist. He has researched diverse areas of people and institutions in the educational setting. Zhou's research stems from his lifelong interest in understanding people and places, which he formally developed since his days as a rural schoolteacher after college. Zhou's current project investigates various aspects of the teaching profession.

Seung-Hwan Ham is an associate professor of education at Hanyang University, Seoul, South Korea. His current research aims to identify the characteristics of effective policies and leadership practices for educational and social inclusion of diverse students. His papers have appeared in many journals not only in education but also in the social sciences broadly, including *American Journal of Education*, *Journal of Teacher Education*, *International Journal of Intercultural Relations*, *Policy Studies*, and *Social Policy & Administration*. He is currently serving on the editorial boards of several renowned journals, including *Journal of Educational Administration*, *Frontiers in Education*, and *Multicultural Education Review*.

Table A1. Background of interviewed tutors.

Name	Degree	Teaching subject(s)	Year(s) of teaching in SEOs	Year(s) of teaching in public schools (if any)
Mr. He	Master	English	5	NA
Mr. Hua	Bachelor	Chinese	9	NA
Mr. Jiang	Bachelor	Chinese	2	NA
Mr. Jin	Bachelor	Mathematics	3	NA
Mr. Kong	Master	Mathematics	3	NA
Mr. Lyu	Bachelor	Math, Physics, and Chemistry	2	NA
Mr. Sun	Bachelor	Mathematics	3	NA
Mr. Tao	Master	English	7	NA
Mr. Wei (卫)	Master	Chinese	2	NA
Mr. Xu	Bachelor	Mathematics	10	1
Mr. Yan	Bachelor	Mathematics	7	1
Mr. You	Bachelor	Physics	4	NA
Mr. Zhang	Bachelor	Chinese	3	NA
Mr. Zhou	Bachelor	Physics	3	NA
Ms. Cao	Master	English	2	NA
Ms. Chen	Master	History	4	NA
Ms. Chu	Bachelor	English	6	NA
Ms. Feng	Bachelor	Chinese	3	8
Ms. Han	Master	English	4	8
Ms. Li	Bachelor	Mathematics	8	NA
Ms. Qian	Master	Politics	3	NA
Ms. Qin	Bachelor	Chinese	2	NA
Ms. Shen	Master	Physics	1	NA
Ms. Shi	Bachelor	Chinese	5	6
Ms. Wang	Bachelor	Chinese	1	4
Ms. Wei (魏)	Bachelor	Mathematics	2	NA
Ms. Wu	Bachelor	Chinese	3	NA
Ms. Yang	Bachelor	English	8	NA
Ms. Zhao	Master	Chinese	2	NA
Ms. Zheng	Bachelor	Mathematics	5	NA
Ms. Zhu	Bachelor	English	4	NA

Note: All names are pseudonyms.